

Chapter 5

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The connection between linguistic variation and social positioning
- How language and accent have become bases for discrimination
- The definition of language ideology and standard language ideology
- The role of the educational system in the standardization process
- The steps in the language subordination process
- The roles of the speaker and the hearer in the communicative process
- The connection between accent, ideology, and the acceptance or rejection of the communicative burden in an interaction

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the Website

From the textbook

1. From Nunberg (2009 [1983/1997]) consider this paragraph from the “The Decline of Grammar.”

If we are bent on finding a decline in standards, the place to look is not in the language itself but in the way it is talked about. In the profusion of new books and articles on the state of the language, and in most new usage books, the moral note, if it is sounded at all, is either wavering or shrill. What is largely missing is the idea that there is any pleasure or instruction to be derived from considering what makes good usage good. Rather, grammar comes increasingly to be regarded as a mandarin code that requires only ritual justification. And, for all the heated polemics over the importance of grammar, it appears that each party at least implicitly accepts this view.

What is it that Nunberg wants? Is he appealing to linguists, prescriptivists or both? On what basis? The entire piece is available online, for a deeper understanding of his position.

Sample Answer: In my analysis of this piece, Nunberg wants both linguists and prescriptivists to take joy in a well-informed, nonpartisan discussion of grammatical correctness. Nunberg thinks that adhering to prescriptive grammatical rules has become a joyless ritual. He wants people to debate grammar problems as divorced from political opinions about liberalism or conservatism and to make informed decisions about their grammatical constructions based on such debates rather than just learning them by rote.

2. How might Accommodation Theory serve as a tool to analyze disagreement more generally? Can you reconstruct an argument you've had (or can imagine having) using the idea of the communicative burden?

Sample Answer: Accommodation Theory can be used as a tool to analyze disagreement in general because people will try harder to understand the point of view of any interlocutor if they

choose to affiliate themselves with that person socially. If a person chooses to distance him- or herself from the interlocutor, then he or she may not try to find a communicative middle ground from which to resolve the argument.

I can imagine rejecting my fair share of the communicative burden in a disagreement in which my interlocutor is a stranger to me and does not have any power over me, and/or in a disagreement in which I strongly dislike my interlocutor's point but fear (or know) that my interlocutor is right. In the first case, I just might not take the trouble to sort out the disagreement if there will be no social ramifications for either of us, and in the second case, I might try hard *not* to understand so as to avoid an unpleasant truth about myself or the world.

3. Do you remember an occasion when you witnessed or overheard one person refusing to understand another, though the communicative content was clear? Why was the communicative burden rejected?

Sample Answer: I have heard a classmate refusing to understand our teaching assistant, who was from Russia. The teaching assistant had an accent, but she was very understandable, especially after being in her discussion section for a couple of weeks. The student had asked a question and the teaching assistant gave a very clear, good explanation for this student, but he kept asking her to clarify or restate what she had said. I had understood the teaching assistant perfectly the first time, but this student was getting frustrated and started cutting the teaching assistant off with more questions as she was trying to explain again. Finally, the student gave up and just said, "Never mind" in an exasperated voice.

I think this student rejected his communicative burden because he felt entitled as a native English speaker to communicate without expending any effort. I also think that he came into the interaction with a prejudice against our teaching assistant because of her accent. He expected to be unable to understand her because of her accent, and then he made that a self-fulfilling prophecy by not fulfilling his share of the communicative burden.

4. Discuss how standard language ideology has been a positive or negative force in your own life or your family's. Has it afforded you advantages, or disadvantages? How have you used language ideology yourself?

Sample Answer: Standard language ideology has afforded me some advantages in my life, since I grew up in a family and area that speaks a valued variety of American English. Since my language variety has been held up as pretty close to the norm, I haven't had to experience linguistic discrimination. I notice my own language ideology crop up in regards to standard spelling and political protest signs. In general, I have no problem with spelling "errors" in documents, and I do not consider nonstandard spelling to indicate a person's intelligence. But, when I see a political sign or statement from the opposite party that contains spelling errors, I take some glee in silently deriding that person for being "an idiot." This is a very judgmental and hypocritical aspect of my language ideology and is something I am working on.

5. Consider this contribution to an online discussion of accents that are attractive or displeasing:

I cannot stand anyone with a thick Black southern accent, it sounds racist but I seriously cannot understand when the people try to communicate to me. Example: I called my cell company and I needed help with why my email pop system did not work. The guy had a half Ebonics/southern slang accent. Trying to explain to me technical shit I had to do. It was super annoying. I had to have him keep repeating to me what the hell he was saying, it was embarrassing me for me, and probably for him or not.

How is (or isn't) this an example of language ideology at work? If not language ideology, what is going on here?

Sample Answer: In my opinion, this is definitely an example of language ideology at work, and in this case, the author's language ideology is connected to racial prejudice. This author did not take his or her share of the communicative burden and feels justified in doing so because s/he strongly dislikes the customer service representative's accent. I also think part of this person's reaction to the customer service representative's accent is based on the fact that the representative was explaining technical information in a nonstandard accent, which the author may have resented because it violates his or her language ideology which would require *SAE for such a discussion.

6. Read "Help for today's Eliza Doolittles," a newspaper article that appeared in the Christian Science Monitor (Gardner, November 3, 1999). How does this article demonstrate the language subordination process? What steps are used? Why is the tone relevant?

Sample Answer: This article demonstrates the language subordination process in several ways. For example, it suggests that nonnative English speakers will reap many social and economical rewards if they conform to as standard a pronunciation as possible, and if they choose not to conform, they may face serious repercussions, such as a glass ceiling at work and possible malpractice lawsuits for doctors. It also describes people who speak with an L2 accent as buying in to this language ideology and working within the language subordination model. In addition, it suggests that nonnative speakers should consult experts who will educate them on how to speak "properly." The article even presents the issue of accent discrimination as a pesky issue that hinders employers from justifiably asking an employee to attend accent reduction classes. The tone of this piece is important because it presents standard language ideology as totally natural and attempts at accent reduction as positive endeavors.

7. Consider two (unlikely, but useful) scenarios:

- a. *Walking along the street in London, you come around a corner face to face with Mick Jagger. He's wearing a torn concert t-shirt and ripped jeans, and he grabs you by the arm. His breath is bad, and he's slurring his words. He is looking for his runaway terrier and he's talking very fast. You don't understand everything he says in his high agitation, but it's clear he wants your help.*

- b. *You're waiting for a bus in a small crowd of people when a shabbily dressed stranger who looks a lot like Mick Jagger approaches you, slowly and with deference. In a very heavily accented English (maybe it's Polish, you think, or some other Eastern European language) this person asks for directions.*

Are you equally willing to help in both situations? Do you in fact help both these people? If not, how do you handle it?

Sample Answer: I would be more willing to go out of my way to understand and help Mick Jagger, but I would also try to help the Mick Jagger look-alike to get his directions. Before taking this class, I would have thought it was perfectly justifiable to expend more effort in helping Mick Jagger than an anonymous stranger, but now I think that my reaction is based in part on Mick Jagger's fame and in part on my unwillingness to accept my full communicative burden with a stranger with an accent.

From the website

Audio

1. In Chapter 5, the author describes how speakers of devalued varieties of English sometimes buy in to the standard language ideology. The author mentions speakers who sound like they are Chilean, Muslim, or Mississippian as examples of people with accents that may start to denigrate their own language varieties. Listen to the samples of these accents found in the International Dialects of English Archive and the Speech Accent Archive and discuss why these speakers might become complicit in their own language subordination.

Sample Answer: All of these accents differ from the mythical *SAE because they betray the geographical area of origin of the speaker. The idea of a standard language is that a listener shouldn't be able to tell where a speaker is from (although they might be able to guess where a speaker is *not* from). Since these speakers' accents differ from this mythical standard, their language varieties are devalued. As society repeatedly tells and shows these speakers that their language varieties are devalued, they may begin to believe that themselves, and may try to change their dialect to sound more like the idea of *SAE.

2. In Chapter 5, the author describes instances of resistance to the dominant language ideology and gives examples related to South Carolinian English, Hawai'ian Creole, AAVE, and Cambodian-American English. Listen to the samples of these language varieties found in the International Dialects of English Archive and the Speech Accent Archive. What strategies can speakers like these use to resist language subordination?

Sample Answer: Speakers of devalued language varieties such as these can resist the language subordination process in several ways. For example, they can choose not to pursue accent reduction training, can organize to validate their language varieties in their communities and beyond, and they can use the court system to combat linguistic discrimination.

3. Listen to the samples of AAVE, French-accented English, and Asian-accented English from the International Dialects of English Archive. What shapes a person's reaction to certain

accents? Why do you think some people have a positive reaction to French accents but a negative reaction to Asian accents or AAVE?

Sample Answer: A person's language ideology affects his or her reaction to a particular accent, so some accents will bring up positive associations for some and negative associations for others. I think that many people have a positive association with French accents because there is general admiration of French culture (with some exceptions of course). Many people consider France to be a center for fashion, art, food, etc., and think highly of French culture. For these people, the French language, and by extension, a French accent, is associated with romance and sophistication and is therefore valued. However, there are not such positive connotations associated with Asian accents or AAVE for many people, despite admiration for aspects of Asian and African American cultures. A layer of racial prejudice muddies the perception of these accents and causes them to be devalued more often than French accents.

Video

"English Lesson"

From G's to Gents

Season 2, Episode 3, Sneak Peek

<http://www.mtv.com/videos/misc/342620/english-lesson.jhtml#id=1605219>

This video clip provides material for discussion of language subordination.

1. How does the content of this video illustrate the language subordination process?

Sample Answer: This video illustrates the language subordination process in several ways. For example, the instructor in this clip tells his students that they do not speak "proper" English, and that they will need to speak "proper" English in certain contexts. This statement implies that the students will be cut off from privileges if they resist "proper" English but will receive rewards from society if they adopt *SAE in certain contexts. Also, many of the students in this clip seem to buy into the notion that their language needs to be changed. For example, when the teacher makes the statement that they will need to use "proper" English in some contexts, one student nods his agreement with this ideology. In addition, this clip demonstrates the subordinating power of an educational institution, even one that, in this case, is presumably created for the purpose of the show.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Standard language ideology glorifies the idea of one homogenous language variety being used by everyone in a nation. Ask the students if they think this is something we should strive for. Do they think it could ever be possible? Why or why not?

2. Many people who subscribe to standard language ideology argue that all children should be educated in the standard language variety so that all children have an equal chance for social and economic advancement. What do your students think about this argument and why do they feel the way they do?

3. Ask your students why they think many people who believe they speak *SAE feel perfectly justified in rejecting their share of the communicative burden when talking with a speaker of a devalued variety of English.
4. Which accents have especially positive or negative associations for your students? Why do they think they feel the way they do?
5. Have your students ask five people to list the three foreign accents they like the most and the three foreign accents they like the least. After their data have been collected, ask the students to look for any patterns in their results. Are there any accents that were mentioned as a favorite several times? Are there any accents that were mentioned as a least favorite several times? How would the students explain any patterns they find? Have the students share their findings with their classmates and reflect on what their results reveal about language ideologies in your area.
6. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.